

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY

 VULNERABILITY REPORT

**Admin Access Without Credentials Puts
40,000+ WordPress Sites at Risk**

Date of Publication

January 16, 2026

Admiralty Code

A1

TA Number

TA2026017

Summary

First Seen: January 13, 2026

Affected Products: Modular DS Connector Plugin

Impact: A critical flaw tracked as CVE-2026-23550 has turned the Modular DS Connector plugin from a site management convenience into a serious security liability, enabling attackers to gain full WordPress administrator access with a single crafted request. By exploiting a broken authentication check in the plugin’s API, threat actors can bypass security controls, log in as an administrator without credentials, and take complete control of affected sites, no user interaction or prior access required. Actively exploited since mid-January 2026, CVE-2026-23550 affects tens of thousands of installations and has already been abused to create rogue admin accounts, opening the door to malware deployment, data theft, and content manipulation. For WordPress site owners, this represents an immediate and high-impact risk, making urgent upgrades to the patched version critical to preventing full site compromise.

CVE

CVE	NAME	AFFECTED PRODUCT	ZERO-DAY	CISA KEV	PATCH
CVE-2026-23550	WordPress Modular DS Privilege Escalation Vulnerability	Modular DS Connector Plugin			

Vulnerability Details

#1

CVE-2026-23550 is a critical privilege escalation flaw affecting the Modular DS Connector plugin for WordPress, a tool widely used to manage multiple WordPress sites through centralized monitoring, updates, and backups. At its core, the issue stems from how the plugin exposes sensitive API routes under the `/api/modular-connector/` path. These routes follow a Laravel-style routing model and are intended to be shielded by authentication middleware to prevent unauthorized access to administrative functions. However, weaknesses in this protection layer leave these endpoints dangerously exposed.

#2

The vulnerability originates from a poorly implemented `isDirectRequest()` method within the plugin's HTTP utilities. By simply supplying an `origin` parameter set to `mo` and a `type` parameter with any arbitrary value, an attacker can convince the application that the request is a trusted "Modular direct request." This logic flaw allows the request to bypass authentication checks entirely. Critically, the mechanism lacks even basic security controls such as cryptographic verification, shared secrets, IP allowlisting, or strict User-Agent validation, making the bypass trivial to exploit.

#3

In practice, attackers exploited this flaw by sending crafted HTTP GET requests to the `/api/modular-connector/login/` endpoint with the bypass parameters. Once past authentication, the vulnerable code path in the `AuthController` automatically selects an administrator account via the `getAdminUser()` function when no specific user ID is supplied. The application then logs the attacker in as an administrator and issues valid authentication cookies, effectively handing over full control of the WordPress dashboard without any credentials.

#4

All versions of the Modular Connector plugin from its initial release through version 2.5.1 are affected, putting more than 40,000 active installations at risk, particularly sites already connected to the Modular DS service with valid or renewable tokens. The severity is reflected in its CVSS 3.1 score of 10.0, highlighting remote exploitation with no privileges or user interaction required and complete compromise potential. Active exploitation was first observed on January 13, 2026, with attackers creating rogue administrator accounts, often using "admin"-like usernames and placeholder email addresses. Successful attacks can lead to total site takeover, malware deployment, data theft, and content manipulation. Users are strongly advised to upgrade immediately to version 2.5.2 or later to mitigate this risk.

Vulnerability

CVE ID	AFFECTED PRODUCTS	AFFECTED CPE	CWE ID
CVE-2026-23550	Modular DS Modular Connector (Before 2.5.2)	cpe:2.3:a:modular:ds:modular_connector.*.*.*.*.*	CWE-284

Recommendations



Update Modular Connector Immediately: Install version 2.5.2 or later of the Modular Connector plugin without delay. This update addresses the authentication bypass vulnerability by removing URL-based route matching and implementing proper route selection that defaults to a 404 response for unrecognized request types. The update can be applied through the Modular DS dashboard, WordPress admin panel (Plugins → Installed Plugins → Update Now).



Audit WordPress Administrator Accounts: Conduct a thorough review of all administrator accounts in your WordPress installations. Look for any unfamiliar or suspicious accounts, particularly those with generic usernames containing "admin" or email addresses ending in @example.com or other bogus domains. Remove any unauthorized accounts immediately and reset passwords for all legitimate administrator accounts to ensure credentials have not been compromised.



Analyze Server Access Logs: Review web server access logs for indicators of attempted or successful exploitation. Search for HTTP GET requests targeting the "/api/modular-connector/login/" endpoint, especially those containing the parameters "origin=mo" and "type=" with arbitrary values. Pay special attention to requests originating from the known malicious IP addresses 45[.]11[.]89[.]19 and 185[.]196[.]10[.]11, as well as automated scanners identified by User-Agent strings such as Python-urllib, curl, or Go-http-client.



Regenerate OAuth Credentials: For sites connected to Modular DS, regenerate the OAuth credentials and connection keys through the Modular DS dashboard under Site Settings → Connection Keys → Regenerate Keys. Reconnect the website using the new credentials to ensure any potentially compromised authentication tokens are invalidated.



Implement Web Application Firewall Rules: Deploy or update web application firewall rules to block requests matching the exploitation pattern. Configure rules to reject requests to "/api/modular-connector/" endpoints that contain the "origin=mo" parameter from external sources. Consider implementing rate limiting and IP-based blocking for the identified malicious IP addresses.



Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Resource Development	T1588 : Obtain Capabilities	T1588.006 : Vulnerabilities
Initial Access	T1190 : Exploit Public-Facing Application	
Privilege Escalation	T1068 : Exploitation for Privilege Escalation	
Persistence	T1136 : Create Account	
Credential Access	T1539 : Steal Web Session Cookie	



✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
IPv4	45[.]11[.]89[.]19, 185[.]196[.]0[.]11

✂ Patch Links

<https://wordpress.org/plugins/modular-connector/>

<https://help.modulards.com/en/article/modular-ds-security-release-modular-connector-252-dm3mv0/>

✂ References

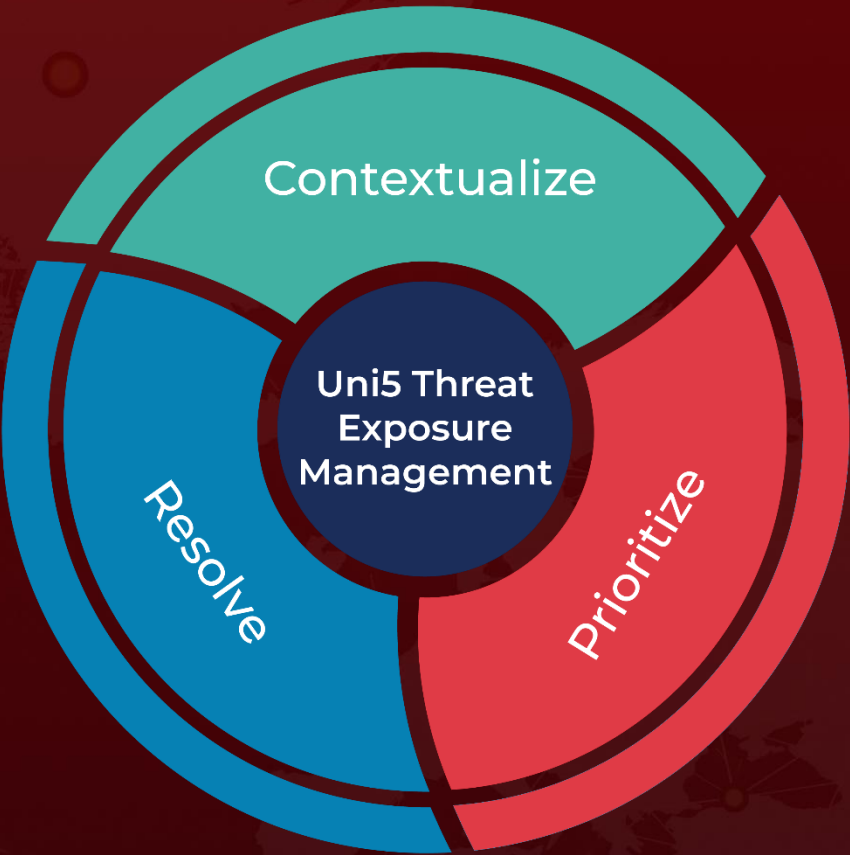
<https://patchstack.com/articles/critical-privilege-escalation-vulnerability-in-modular-ds-plugin-affecting-40k-sites-exploited-in-the-wild/>

<https://help.modulards.com/en/article/modular-ds-security-release-modular-connector-252-dm3mv0/>

What Next?

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January 16, 2026 • 7:30 AM

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